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KEY INSIGHTS

What drives team effectiveness?

In one of the largest studies on team performance, Google interviewed more than 180 of its teams to understand “What makes a team effective?” The answers surprised them—and they might surprise you as well.



Google’s research found that the composition of the team was **less important than how the team worked together**. The five key dynamics they identified, in order of importance, were:

1



Psychological safety

Team members feel safe to speak up, share ideas, and take risks without fear of judgment.

2



Dependability of team members

Team members are reliable, consistent, and support one another.

3



Structure and clarity of roles and goals

Team members understand their roles, responsibilities, and the team’s goals clearly.

4



Work is meaningful

Team members feel that their work has purpose and is personally meaningful.

5



Work has impact

Team members see that their work creates real impact, both within the organization and for others.



Of these five dynamics, **psychological safety** was, by far, **the most important**. It also underpinned the other four.

YOUR TURN

What drives team effectiveness?

Below are several factors. Based on Google's research, decide which ones are significant drivers of team effectiveness.

 Drag each card to the correct column.



Significant Driver

This factor was found to significantly drive team effectiveness.



Drag and drop here



Not a Significant Driver

This factor was not found to significantly drive team effectiveness.



Drag and drop here



Individual performance of each team member



The work matters and has an impact



Number of years each team member has been on the team



Work is personally meaningful



Seniority of the team members



Psychological safety (take risks, be vulnerable)



Number of team members who are extroverts



Team members are dependable



Size of the team



Clear roles and goals



The team is co-located (same location)

THE ANSWER



Google identified 5 key dynamics that drive team effectiveness

Among all the factors studied, **psychological safety** was the most important, and it also underpinned the other four.

1



Psychological safety

Team members feel safe to speak up, share ideas, and take risks without fear of judgment.

 Most important

2



Dependability of team members

Team members are reliable, consistent, and support one another.

3



Structure and clarity of roles and goals

Team members understand their roles, responsibilities, and the team's goals clearly.

4



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Team members feel that their work has purpose and is personally meaningful.

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What is psychological safety?



Psychological safety has been researched for decades and certainly isn't the sole factor for team success. However, in today's workplace with more diverse and common team structures, it is increasingly important that members unlock their full potential to work together. Teams with psychological safety not only excel in current tasks but also improve over time and adapt better to the future.



As you watch the video, consider:

Take a moment to reflect on the following questions.

1



What is my team doing—or not doing—to **create psychological safety**?

2



What would be different if we **improved our psychological safety**?